



# INDUSTRY NEWS

INDUSTRY UPDATES

## Indian institutes now developing home-grown chips in a big way

Several academic institutes in India are now developing microchips that could soon give competition to renowned chip makers like Intel and Qualcomm, according to an article in a leading newspaper. They are being funded by the government in absence of interest shown by private venture capitalists as this is financially a high-risk area.

At IIT Madras, microprocessor Shakti is being designed using open source architecture under the guidance of Prof. Kamakoti Veezhinathan of Department of Computer Science and Engineering. It is meant to be used in low-power wireless devices like smartphones and surveillance cameras.

IIT Bombay has developed AJIT, a microchip meant for use in GPS receivers for use in Indian satellite navigation system, NAVIC—the Indian regional navigation

satellite system. According to Prof. Madhav Desai of the IIT's electrical engineering department, "If NAVIC becomes successful, there are two to three companies keen to commercialise it."

The Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), Pune—a government-funded research institute—is designing India's first 64-bit quad-core microprocessor. According to C-DAC director-general, Hemant Darbari, they are also working on a range of chips for image processing and smart energy meters.

Though there are challenges at present in the fabrication of such chips in India, it would be reasonable to expect that such proposals lying with NITI Aayog and other government bodies would be approved soon. There is an ever-increasing demand for such chips in India.

## TRAI to go after fibre enhancement to aid 5G rollout

Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) is set to consult with industry stakeholders on enhancing the country's fibre footprint on the backdrop of Narendra Modi government's ambitious 5G technology push. TRAI secretary Sunil K. Gupta told *The Economic Times* that they are preparing a consultation paper on how to enhance fiberisation to help implementation of 5G in the country.

Gupta added that the regulator

would be taking an initial step that includes setting up an agenda for the broader consultation, which would include current footprint status, existing bottlenecks, and ways and means to increase fibre penetration.

India's fibre penetration, according to industry estimates, is extremely low, and despite 5G technology around the corner, only 25 per cent of the 500,000 telecom towers in India are fiberised—an essential backhaul requirement for high-speed data net-

## On The Move

### MAIT appoints George Paul as CEO

Manufacturers' Association for Information Technology (MAIT), the apex body representing India's information and communications technology and electronics hardware manufacturing, R&D and training service sectors, has appointed its new chief executive officer, George Paul. Paul brings 30 years of industry experience in IT hardware products, electronic sub-systems, mechatronics, avionics, mechanical engineering, aerospace and IT services.

### Centre appoints Navneet Gupta as Joint Secretary in telecom department

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet has named Navneet Gupta, an Indian Audit & Account Service (IAAS) 1997-batch officer, as Joint Secretary in Department of Telecommunications (DoT). In December 2018, Gupta was enrolled for holding the post of Joint Secretary or equivalent in the Union government.

### Samsung's Sumit Walia joins Oppo as VP

Oppo has appointed Sumit Walia as vice president (VP) for its product and marketing division in India. Walia, who started his career in the consumer electronics domain in 2001, was previously working with Samsung as director and category head of mobile business for smartphones and feature phones priced below US\$ 300.

work deployments.

The government, as a part of the recently-unveiled national policy, also aims to establish National Fibre Authority (NFA); however, Department of Telecom (DoT) is yet to take further steps. It aims to increase the fibre footprint to fivefold by 2022, from the current 1.5 million route kilometres.